

A TALL ORDER
Congress candidate Digvijaya Singh (centre) campaigning along with the party's state unit chief, Jitendra Patwari, and other leaders at Khilchipur in Rajgarh constituency, which went to the polls on May 7

Modi factor and Hindutva rhetoric to help him sail through. Ironically, several candidates, like Union minister Faggan Singh Kulaste, Ganesh Singh, Alok Sharma and Bharat Singh Kushwah, who tasted defeat in the state election, have been awarded Lok Sabha tickets—a perplexing decision, to say the least.

What's more perplexing is the fact that the BJP's much-vaunted organisational prowess, often touted as its greatest asset, has somehow faltered in delivering during the initial two polling rounds. Its 'Mission 370' project—aimed at securing 370 seats in the Lok Sabha by capitalising on the abrogation of Article 370—had tasked the cadre with increasing the party's tally by 370 votes across Madhya Pradesh's 65,000-odd booths. However, this target has been rendered ambitious, with voter turnout dipping by 7-8 percentage points in the first two phases. "Clearly, the organisation's claims of increasing votes remain on paper," says political analyst Girija Shankar. "This is because while the high command has issued directives, workers are sitting at home." There is a perceptible drop in enthusiasm, especially among women voters, and some insiders link this to the "marginalisation" of former chief minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan, the architect of women-centric schemes like Ladli Behna.

The only hope for the Congress lies in capitalising on such 'missteps' of the ruling party to corner some seats. Jitendra 'Jitu' Patwari, who took the reins of the state Congress after the party's rout in the assembly polls last December, has put a basic strategy in place. Deciding not to spread the party machinery too thin, he has decided to mainly focus on the 15-odd Lok Sabha seats where the Congress has a "realistic" chance of winning and putting up just a token fight on the remaining seats that it has not won for the past five elections.

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The party per se is concentrating on two types of seats—high-profile ones, such as Chhindwara and Rajgarh, and those lying in the state's tribal belt, where it performed well in the assembly polls. Though the Congress's tally in the 47 seats reserved for the scheduled tribes (STs) dipped from 31 to 22, members of the tribal communities account for a third of the party's 66 candidates who entered the state legislature.

Tribals constitute 21 per cent of the state's population and there are six Lok Sabha seats reserved for them—Dhar, Betul, Shahdol, Ratlam, Mandla and Khargone. Besides, Chhindwara, Balaghat, Sidhi and Morena have a substantial tribal vote that can swing the outcome in anyone's favour. In Mandla, the Congress fielded Omkar Markam, a tribal strongman, against Union minister Kulaste, while in Ratlam, it bet on the old warhorse Kantilal Bhuria against Anita Chauhan, wife of the state forest minister Nagar Singh Chauhan.

All in all, though, the Congress appears organisationally feeble, hardly extending any tangible support to its candidates. Left to fend for themselves, only those with formidable political clout stand a chance of putting up a fight. Tragically, the party has failed to create a buzz around its manifesto promises, such as the Rs 1 lakh unconditional cash transfer annually to the poorest of the poor families, legal guarantee for minimum support prices, paid apprenticeships for graduates and educational loan waivers—pledges that could have galvanised the electorate. As the Mohan Yadav regime reneged on the BJP's pre-assembly poll guarantee of procuring wheat at Rs 2,700 per quintal and paddy at Rs 3,100, Patwari endeavoured to raise this critical issue, pivotal for the state's predominantly agrarian population. However, his efforts have found little resonance on the ground—a lost opportunity that could prove costly for the party. ■